# A National Airspace System Reference Architecture as a System of Systems

## Tracing Operational Intent from Enterprise Objectives to Aircraft Trajectory

ISD 503 Capstone Project Report – Interim Report #2

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October 14, 2026

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S1** — Confirm advisor/reader name and title for "Submitted to."

# Executive Summary

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S14, S16** — Write this section LAST. Distill: (1) the improvement opportunity/problem statement, (2) the MBSE approach used, (3) major architecture and optimization-demonstration findings stated quantitatively, (4) the operational impact/benefit of the reference architecture (see Section 5), and (5) recommendations. Limit to 1-2 pages; no citations, undefined terms, or content not found elsewhere in the report. State the two claims here as well as in the Introduction (Section 1; owner's note on the 2026-10-11 print, page 11).

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# 1 Introduction

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S1** — Briefly state the subject, purpose, and scope of the report: the NAS modeled as a System of Systems, centered on how operational intent propagates from enterprise objectives to aircraft trajectory/behavior.

This project builds a reference MBSE architecture for how airspace intent is managed across the National Airspace System (NAS). The architecture spans the organizations that define and enforce rules, the domains that manage airspace resources, the systems that support flight operations, and the onboard systems that turn intent into an executable trajectory and guidance behavior.

DeLaurentis [16] states the problem as follows:

> "Problems of significant complexity are facing decision-makers within government and industry, and the moniker of 'system-of-systems' (heretofore shortened to SoS) is increasingly being applied to problems of this type. Effective system analysis for decision-support quickly becomes unmanageable in this context, with multiple, heterogeneous, distributed systems involved and couched in networks at multiple levels. The situation is exacerbated by the fact that most organizations (and their processes) remain in the 'stovepipe' mode – their people and tools are configured to study within narrow bins with little or no analysis across those bins. Current frames of reference, thought processes, analysis, and design methods are not complete for these SoS problems ... A holistic framework is needed that enables decision makers to discern whether related infrastructure, policy, and/or technology considerations together are good, bad (or indifferent) over time."

The statement dates from 2005, but still describes the NAS today. The NAS is a system of systems, and the decisions its stakeholders make have consequences for the safety, efficiency, and sustainability of air transportation.

Airlines invest significant time and money in operational plans that maximize revenue. On the day of operation, unpredictable events – bad weather, aircraft malfunctions, crew absenteeism – can substantially alter that plan and the revenue objectives behind it [11]. To manage this, airlines maintain an Airline Operations Control Center (AOCC), a department of specialists in disruption management across aircraft, crew, and passenger recovery. The AOCC monitors operations and makes real-time decisions – re-routing flights, rescheduling crews, rebooking passengers – intended to limit the effect of a disruption on the airline's schedule and revenue.

The literature does not converge on one standard definition of the "cost" the AOCC is minimizing, and the values it does quantify do not always hold up under scrutiny. The optimization literature commonly models delay cost as a linear function of delay minutes, but Hu et al. [44] note that this is inconsistent with airline practice, where delay cost is a nonlinear function of delay time, and that, faced with this complexity, airlines tend to put the speed of a recovery decision ahead of the mathematical optimality of the solution. The same preference for fast, tractable decisions shows up in how the work is structured. A review of the Aircraft Recovery Problem finds that studies – and, by extension, the AOCC processes they model – rarely minimize delay, cancellations, and aircraft swaps together. They treat aircraft, crew, and passenger recovery as separable sub-problems, solved in sequence and handed off in turn [77]. Each stage can produce a solution that is locally optimal yet globally suboptimal, or even infeasible, once the next stage's constraints are applied. This is a documented instance of the myopic-optimization pattern this capstone investigates.

The pattern is visible even in work that improves on the status quo. The predictive turnaround-buffer allocation model of Kontodimou et al. [56] achieves a 37.1% reduction in propagated delay

relative to a zero-buffer baseline, but it reaches that result by holding aircraft routing, fleet assignment, crew duty, maintenance, and passenger connectivity fixed as upstream constraints, outside the optimization. The gain is real within that scope. The framing also shows the risk this capstone is concerned with: a locally optimized decision layer can report a strong local benefit while passing tradeoffs to adjacent decision layers that its own cost model does not measure. The same pattern appears on the human side of the AOCC. Turhan, Gzara, and Elhedhli [89] document that when dispatcher workload exceeds capacity, dispatchers "may resort to conservative approaches, which can have financial implications for airlines" – a workload-driven cost that rarely appears in the delay, cancellation, and swap cost models discussed above. Hassan, Santos, and Vink [36] frame this more broadly as a persistent gap between the disruption-management optimization literature and AOCC practice.

This report explores the value tradeoffs aviation stakeholders experience when a disruption occurs and the recovery decision is made with more or less myopia. A dispatcher or AOCC team member making a decision is often focused on its immediate effect – for example, minimizing delay for one flight – without visibility into what it means for the airline's wider operation or for the NAS as a whole. The cost models in use today are over simplifications that capture the factors easiest to quantify, such as fuel and crew cost. Factors that are harder to quantify – maintenance cost, passenger satisfaction, dispatcher and controller workload, environmental impact – are more often left out. The result can be congestion in particular airspace sectors, missed opportunities for more efficient routing, or lower profit driven by customer dissatisfaction. By modeling the NAS as a system of systems and tracing how operational intent propagates through it, the project aims to identify ways to improve these decisions and reduce the cost of disruptions to the air transportation system.

Two claims are central to the project. The first, explored by the experiment, is that replacing a low-fidelity rule of thumb with a higher-fidelity model fed by accurate performance models and informed of the broader state of the airspace can and will lead to changes in how disruptions are mitigated. The second, shown by the model, is that an MBSE architecture can locate that interface, name who owns the decision and the data, state the unmet requirement, and lets the scoring model's fidelity be swapped (conceptual, nominal mass, actual mass) with the structure unchanged. As such, the model contributes is a traceable representation of how strategic objectives become executable aircraft behavior.

## 1.1 Overview of the Project

In the NAS, operational decisions are made by independent actors, each of which may or may not account for the effect on the others. Those actors include regulatory agencies, air traffic service providers, airport operators, airline operations centers, maintenance (MRO) suppliers, flight crews, passengers, and the aircraft systems themselves. Substantial architectural work exists within individual domains, but the relationships and information flows between domains are often incompletely represented.

Existing models frequently focus on one actor or one problem, and show one or more of the following limitations:

- emphasis on enterprise-level capabilities without sufficient representation of aircraft behavior and onboard decision-making;
- emphasis on aircraft systems without adequate representation of the operational context in which those systems operate;

- limited traceability between strategic objectives, operational constraints, human decisions, and the resulting aircraft trajectories;
- difficulty evaluating the effect of new operational concepts, automation technologies, and optimization services across organizational boundaries.

As a result, no broadly applicable architecture fully captures how strategic objectives become executable aircraft behavior. Without end-to-end traceability, engineers, operators, and decision makers have limited means to understand the consequences of a change within the NAS, and integrating future decision-support technology is harder than it needs to be.

This project addresses that gap by developing a System-of-Systems architecture that explicitly models the propagation of intent through the NAS, from enterprise objectives and airspace management decisions to flight deck decision-making and aircraft trajectory execution.

## 1.2 Literature Review

A literature review explored the makeup of the NAS more generally and the various problem spaces that it contains. The identified literature can be categorically organized as follows:

- Long-horizon strategic airline planning and operations
- Day-of-operations and collaborations necessary to begin a flight's execution
- Tactical flight execution and disruption management

Airline planning and operations literature focused on schedule planning, fleet assignment, crew scheduling, and maintenance routing. In general these operations consist of a series of optimization problems that are solved sequentially, long before a flight enters the NAS, and the chosen solutions define the input conditions to the day-of-operations and turnaround, and OCC/dispatch and flight execution problem spaces, which are more directly relevant to the intent-to-trajectory problem space this capstone addresses.

The literature focused on day-of operations explored how airlines and airports coordinate to manage flight schedules, gate assignments, and turnaround times, as well as how weight and balance considerations affect aircraft performance and safety. The OCC/dispatch and flight execution literature focused on disruption management, dispatcher responsibilities, and nominal ATC/IFR flow.

Very few of the sources utilized a systems engineering approach to model the problem space and the relationships between the various actors and systems. [58] developed a model of the NAS using MBSE to represent the various actors and systems, but it did not focus on the propagation of intent through the system and did not publish their models publicly.

The EU Greener Air Traffic Operations (GREAT) project [43] developed a model of the NAS using MBSE to represent the various actors and systems, which was the most comprehensive found. On page 37 the authors explore the modifications made to a flight throughout the cruise phase and how those are communicated and coordinated between the various actors and systems. However, the GREAT project did not address the value of detailed state information and the effect of that information on decision-making and trajectory execution.

The lack of modelling is a gap in the existing research, which this capstone addresses by developing a System-of-Systems architecture that explicitly models the propagation of intent through the NAS, from enterprise objectives and airspace management decisions to flight deck decision-making and aircraft trajectory execution.

The gap represented by the lack of information exchange and the effect of that information on decision-making and trajectory execution is addressed by the experiment, which evaluates the effect of providing additional information to the ATC sector controller on the resulting trajectory and its associated costs. [15] measured what airline-supplied weight does for climb prediction. Much work has explored the potential value of EPP, which will provide for downlink of the FMS's predicted profile, but it has not been widely implemented and it does not provide for what-iffing.

Furthermore, the experiment explores the impact of how the controller defines optimality when resolving a conflict between two aircraft. This project bridges these gaps by:

- scoring one decision at four stakeholder levels side by side (aircraft, airline, sector, system) with no weighted sum, so who pays is visible;
- mapping the decision to its authority and its information owner in a system-of-systems model, so the missing exchange is a named interface and an unmet requirement, not a finding in prose;
- swapping the scoring model's fidelity under a fixed architecture and measuring its impact, which is the MBSE claim.

In the moments when the conflicts occur and disruption managment must occur, the controller has type, level, speed and route, but not weight or cost index. [79] describes how weight and speed intent "are considered competitive parameters by airlines and are not available for use". As such, the what-iffing aspect of the additional interfaces must be executed carefully and with security in mind.

[73] describes how this lack of information leads to simplified solutions, where controllers "use more predetermined rules", leading to 23 of 36 level-crossing cases resolved by a descent. This simplification is further supported by the findings of [55], whos investigations determined that controllers "leave the aircraft in steady state alone, and by [34] who quoted one controller as stating there's "No point asking aircraft to climb if they come back and say they can't".

[19] explored the value of providing traffic information to the flight deck where it can be combined with performance data to determine optimal trajectories, and found that it led to a reduction in fuel burn and time for the typical case. This project is a mirror-image study, where the traffic picture is provided to the controller instead of the flight deck, and the effect on the trajectory and its associated costs are measured. The study did not model aircraft weight and limited climbs to FL350 and below for that reason. This is exactly the assumption Section 3.2 adopts for a point of comparison.

### 1.3 Current State

For a period the project lacked a specific focus for which tradeoffs it would consider. The project is not an exploration of optimization, but its concept centers on sub-optimality driven by myopic decisions. The concepts of operations gave a more complete understanding of the NAS, the systems involved, and the interfaces among them, but they did not by themselves point to a specific scenario worth modelling.

The pivot from Phase 1 exploration to Phase 2 modelling was made to advance the project deliverables while building a deeper understanding of the information gaps. The intent was that when the modelling reached the measures of effectiveness and performance, the stakeholders' objectives would be revisited and a more targeted consultation of the literature could occur.

Building the model raised questions the literature review alone had not: who owns the decision support for a trajectory change, which party holds the information that decision needs, and whether an exchange between them exists. Answering them located one specific gap. The sector controller

decides which aircraft to move in a conflict, the airline and the flight management system hold the aircraft's weight and cost index, and no exchange carries one to the other. That gap is now a named interface in the model (`AirlinePerformanceShare`) and an unmet requirement. The literature consultation that followed was targeted in the way the pivot intended: sources on controller conflict-resolution practice [73, 55, 34], on climb prediction with airline-supplied weight [15], and on traffic-aware flight-deck requests [19] were found and read because the model and the experiment needed them.

**AI-DRAFTED, owner to rewrite** — Two sentences added for your note "cite new papers w/ specific facts (TASAR, Mori)". The figures are from Claude's reading notes in `evidence/literature-notes/summaries/` (TASAR pp. 8 and 12; Mori p. 1 and its results), not from your own reading. Check them against the papers and choose the facts you want.

The traffic-aware requests study, for example, reported a saving of 27 gallons of fuel and 2.3 minutes per flight in its typical case, and it limited climbs to FL350 and below because it did not model aircraft weight [19]. Mori [69] starts from the same absence: aircraft mass is usually not openly available because airlines treat it as confidential, so it estimates the mass from the cruise profile, with a mean absolute error of 3.29 percent over 39 flights of one aircraft type.

The project is now organized as four parallel tracks (model, experiment, report, and evidence on demand) worked in nine one-week turns that end on 2026-12-13. This plan replaced the single-pass August list on 2026-10-10. One traced thread carries the project: the airline's cost objective, the stakeholder and system requirements that follow from it, the airline-to-ATC interface, the conflict-resolution decision, and the experiment that scores that decision.

The requirements have been through two hand reviews and now stand at 13 stakeholder requirements and 23 system requirements, each limited to what bears on the studied decision. A third tier of 28 constituent-system requirements is drafted and not yet reviewed. The model holds the context diagram, an aircraft internal block diagram that has been hand reviewed, an airspace management internal block diagram that is still a placeholder, a draft nominal-flight activity diagram, and the typed airline-to-ATC interface. The state machines the original plan scheduled for 9/15 have not been built.

The experiment is defined and runs end to end. Four aircraft in one generic, overly simplified en-route sector present one crossing conflict, and four cases resolve it with different information: a controller's rule, automation with one assumed nominal weight per aircraft type, automation with the shared weight and cost index, and the same with passenger connection information. An open aircraft performance model, OpenAP, scores every option. The first results are in Section 4.3 and are preliminary.

## 1.4 Stakeholder Selection

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S7** — Identify key project stakeholders (individuals/organizations affected by or perceiving themselves affected by NAS operational decisions). Draw on the PESTLE stakeholder discovery, stakeholder register, and RACCI matrix from to-do-list.md S7. Confirm the stakeholder set is diverse (airline, passenger, ATC/ANSP, airport, flight crew, environmental/societal, military – see S8's per-stakeholder objective categories) and that stakeholders with little formal power (e.g., passengers, communities affected by noise/emissions) are represented.

I created the `capstone_stakeholder_assessment.xlsx` file with an initial assessment of each candidate stakeholder's objectives, then refined it as I read more of the literature and understood the NAS better. For each stakeholder the assessment records:

- the stated interest, and whether it acts as a hard constraint, an optimization objective, a cost or penalty, a measure of performance (MOP), or a measure of effectiveness (MOE);

- candidate MOPs and MOEs;
- whether the stakeholder has a direct or indirect effect on trajectory decisions, if any;
- whether the stakeholder should stand alone or be abstracted through consolidation with another, and the reason.

**AI-DRAFTED, owner to rewrite** — Expansion of the paragraph above (your notes: "expand"; "Add excerpt or put in Appendix and reference"). Every figure is read from the workbook's "Stakeholder Assessment" and "Decision Guide" sheets. The excerpt is Table 8; Claude chose its rows.

The assessment holds 48 candidate stakeholders, grouped by the six domains of a PESTLE analysis (political, economic, social, technological, legal, environmental). Each candidate is scored from two judgments. The first is its importance as a stakeholder in its own right: high (3), medium (2) or low (1). The second is whether a trajectory decision changes its objective: directly (2), indirectly (1) or not at all (0). A total of 5 marks a stakeholder to keep on its own, 3 or 4 one to consider or to consolidate with another, and 1 or 2 one to treat as an input at the boundary or to leave out. An excerpt is in Appendix A.2, Table 8.

An exploration of each stakeholder's interests led to the following list of objectives relevant to the project:

- Safety / Security
- Efficiency
- Throughput / Capacity
- Reliability / Resilience
- Environmental Impact
- Noise Impact
- Passenger Satisfaction
- Schedule Reliability
- Cost / Profitability
- Maintenance / Lifecycle Cost
- Regulatory Compliance
- Workload / Human Factors

**AI-DRAFTED, owner to rewrite** — How the list in Figure 1 was formed (your note: "Add verbiage about how early literature review readings and SME background informed formulation of the list of stakeholders shown in Figure 1"). Claude knows the list was seeded by a PESTLE pass (`knowledge/models/stakeholder-register.md`); which readings and which parts of your experience shaped it is yours to say. The two sources named are ones the Introduction already cites.

The candidates in Figure 1 were the starting point. They came from a PESTLE pass over the NAS, from early readings on airline operations control and disruption management [11, 36], and from the author's experience in the flight management system industry, which supplied the parties that sit between an airline's plan and the trajectory the aircraft flies.

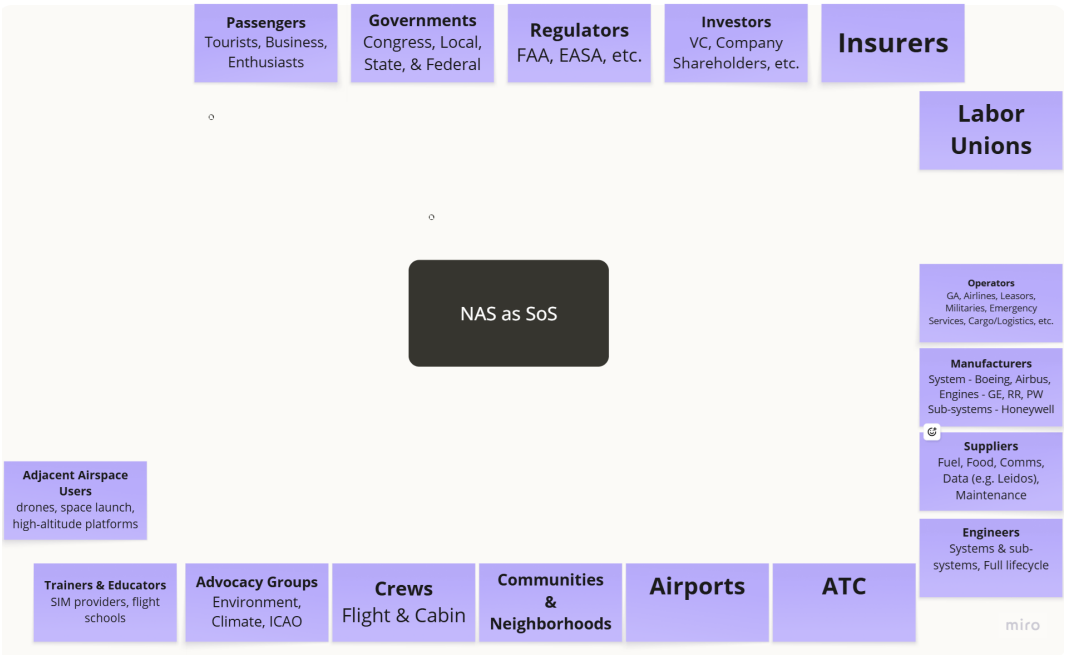



Figure 1: Candidate stakeholders of the NAS as a system of systems.

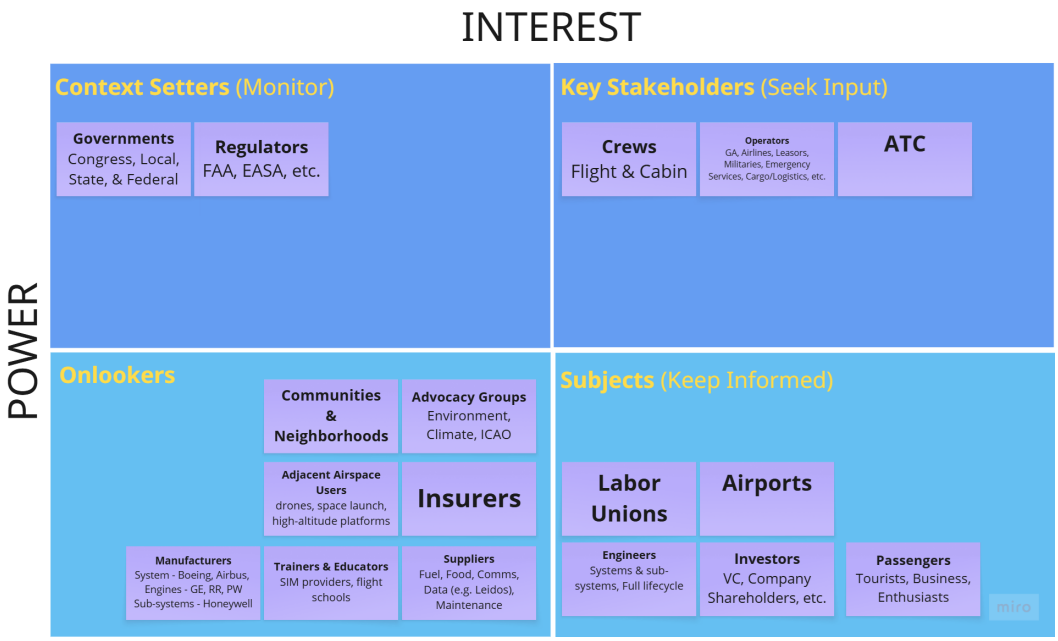



Figure 2: Candidate stakeholders placed by power and interest.

Figure 1 shows the candidate stakeholders first identified, and Figure 2 places them by power and interest.

**AI-DRAFTED, owner to rewrite** — What happened to two groups in Figure 2 (your note: "Talk about how context setters became part of the environment by defining the regulatory environment. Describe how Airports were included b/c of [streaming] and capacity's relevance for decision making and representation in scenario was weak"). "Streaming" is Claude's reading of one handwritten word; correct it. The statement that no airport constraint acts on the scenario is Claude's, from `simulation/scenario_base.yaml`.

The context setters of Figure 2, governments and regulators, became part of the environment. They define the regulatory environment in which the modeled systems operate, and they enter the model as rules, not as parties to an operational decision. Airports are placed among the subjects in Figure 2 and were nonetheless kept as a modeled system, because the streaming of traffic into an airport and the airport's capacity bear on trajectory decisions. Their representation in the experiment's scenario is weak: the scenario is one conflict in cruise, and no airport constraint acts on it.

## 1.5 System Identification and Selection

The aircraft is treated alongside the stakeholders as a constituent system. Figure 3 shows the systems first identified within the NAS, with the aircraft decomposed furthest, as its systems and their performance dictate the cost of each flight.

## 1.6 Scope

**AI-DRAFTED, owner to rewrite** — De-scoping decisions and the final lists (owner's note: "Leave larger list above, discuss de-scoping decisions here and include the final list/diagram"). The reasons in quotation marks are your margin notes. On the 2026-10-13 print you supplied the reasons for profitability, reliability, maintenance and lifecycle cost, and throughput and capacity; they are below in your words. Still Claude's reading, not yours: the reason given for the four stakeholders, and the reason given for security, resilience and regulatory compliance.

The stakeholders, objectives and systems of Sections 1.4 and 1.5 are the result of exploration. The study itself is narrower. It examines one tactical decision, the resolution of a conflict between aircraft in cruise, and keeps only the stakeholders and objectives that bear on that decision.

Four stakeholders remain, together with the aircraft, and each appears on the context diagram (Figure 4): operators, as flight operations and its airline operations center; air traffic control, within airspace management; the airport authority, as airport operations; and the flight crew. The aircraft appears as aircraft systems. Governments and standards organizations, aircraft and engine manufacturers, passengers, and environmental and societal organizations are outside the System of Interest. They supply rules, equipment, demand, and expectations to the decision but do not make it or execute it, so they are treated as boundary actors and not decomposed.

Six stakeholder objectives remain: safety, efficiency, environmental impact, schedule reliability, cost, and workload. Schedule reliability is carried in the experiment as a step in cost when a flight's delay passes a threshold (the parameter $K$ of Section 3.3). The others were set aside for the following reasons. Noise impact: the measure is "not relevant at cruise." Passenger satisfaction: "not measurable objectively." Profitability falls out of the other objectives; it is tracked at the operator's organizational level and is more complex than any one decision. Reliability is captured with schedule reliability. Maintenance and lifecycle cost are largely determined by the number of flight cycles, the chosen takeoff performance, the flight distance and the climb controls, so one air traffic control decision has a negligible effect on them. Security, resilience and regulatory compliance are not changed by the choice between resolution options in the scenario. Throughput

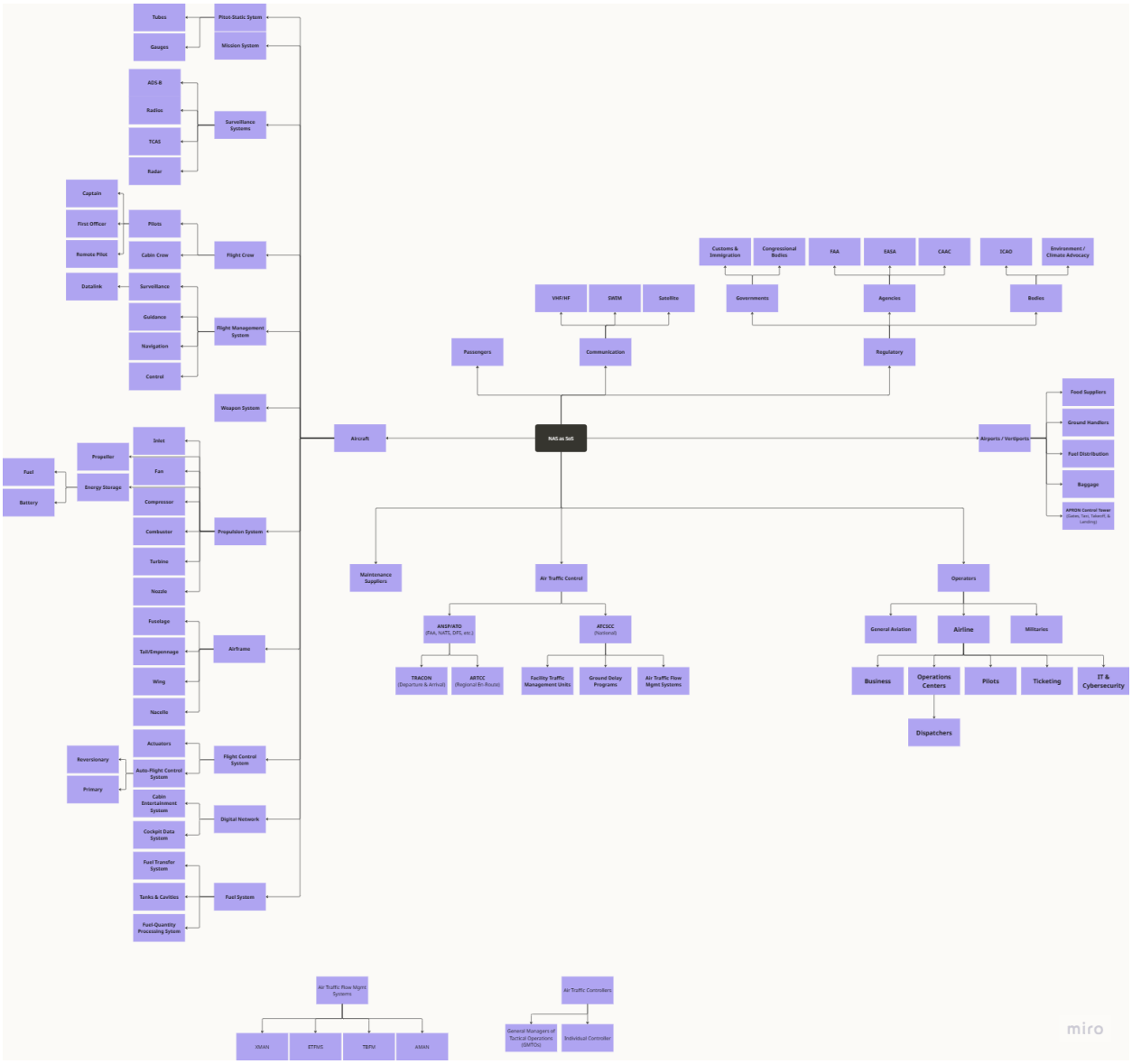



Figure 3: The NAS as a system of systems: candidate constituent systems.

and capacity were left for another study. They are also close to ongoing work by the author, and out of an abundance of caution that part of the problem space was avoided.

Figure 4 is the resulting System of Interest as modeled: the constituent systems kept and the exchanges among them.

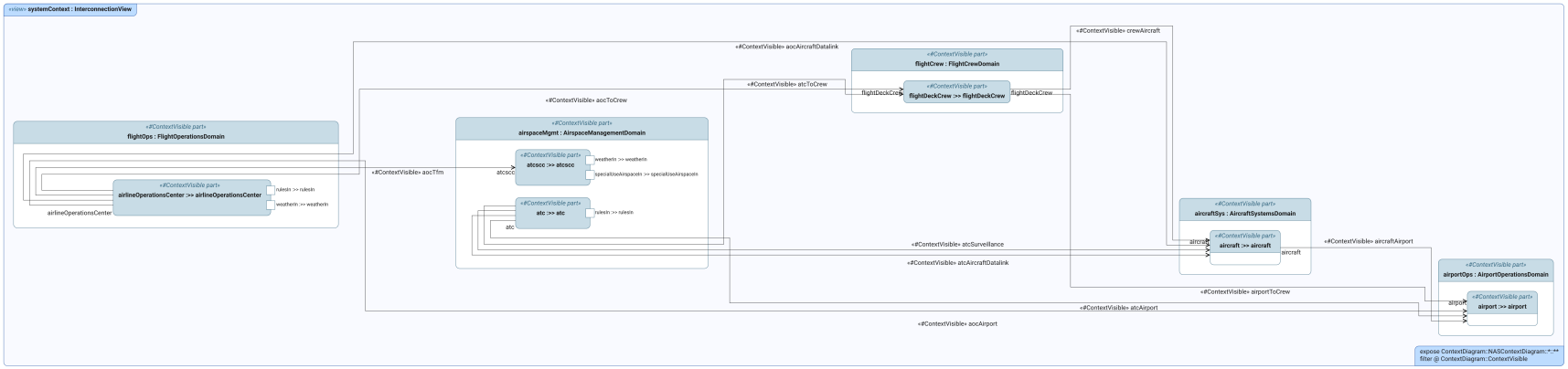



Figure 4: NAS context diagram. View `systemContext`; source `nas_context_diagram.sysml`; rendered 2026-10-10.

## 1.7 Stakeholder Objectives

**AI-DRAFTED, owner to rewrite** — What "optimal" means to each stakeholder, and where the objectives conflict (your note: "DO"). Source: the synthesis section of `knowledge/models/stakeholder-objective-ontology.md`, whose own status note says the classifications are judgment calls not yet sourced from annotated literature. Limited here to the stakeholders and objectives kept in Section 1.6.

Each stakeholder kept in scope pursues a different objective when an aircraft's trajectory is changed. The airline wants the lowest cost for its flights, which combines fuel, time, and the consequences of a late arrival for connecting passengers. Air traffic control wants separation assured with a workload the sector team can sustain, and a traffic picture that stays predictable. The flight crew wants instructions the aircraft can fly, given with enough time to set them up.

Some of these objectives align. Burning less fuel lowers the airline's cost and lowers carbon dioxide emissions together. Air traffic control's wish for predictability and the airline's wish to keep its schedule both favor aircraft that fly what was planned.

Others conflict, and the conflict this project studies is the first of them: the trajectory that is cheapest for one aircraft is not always the one that costs the sector least to grant. A request or a resolution that saves fuel for one flight can add instructions, monitoring, and follow-up for the controller. That cost is externalized. It does not appear in the airline's own cost function, and the party that bears it has no means to price it back.

The objectives also operate on different timescales. An airline sets its schedule policy over months, realizes fuel cost per flight, and realizes delay cost in minutes. Air traffic control manages capacity over years through sector design and over seconds through tactical control. A decision made in minutes by one party is judged against objectives the others hold on other clocks.

## 1.8 Project Deliverables

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S10, S14, S16** — State the goals and deliverables: the SysML reference architecture, the traceability chain from stakeholder needs to aircraft-level behavior, and the experiment (Section 3). Include the quantifiable measures used to assess success (e.g., traceability coverage, stakeholder coverage, demonstration of a local-vs-SoS tradeoff).

**AI-DRAFTED, owner to rewrite** — Proposed deliverables table (your note: "Have Claude propose a table"). The eight rows are your list; Claude read its second word as "bdd". The middle and right columns are Claude's proposal. No block definition diagram or requirements view is rendered yet, and the trace table and the gap analysis are not written: the table says where each will go, not that it is there.

The project delivers the eight items of Table 1.

## 1.9 Project Timing

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S1 (new)** — Revisit the timeline from the 503 Proposal submittal (see `prework/ISD 503 Submittal.pdf`) and show the plan now in force: the nine one-week turns of D-016 (the table at the top of `to-do-list.md`), each with its exit test and target date, next to the August milestones in Table 2.

The plan established at the project's inception is presented in Table 2 for reference, with the status of each item: not started, draft, complete, or will not implement.

Table 1: Project deliverables.

| Deliverable | What it shows | Where in this report |
|---|---|---|
| Context diagram | The systems kept in the System of Interest, the actors at its boundary, and the exchanges among them | Section 1.6 |
| Block definition diagrams | The NAS broken down into domains and constituent systems | Appendix A.3 |
| Internal block diagrams | The parts inside the aircraft and inside airspace management, and the links among them | Section 4.2 |
| Activity diagrams | One nominal flight from gate to gate, and the place of the conflict within it | Section 4.1 |
| Requirements | Stakeholder requirements, system requirements and constituent-system requirements, each traced to the tier above | Appendix A.3 |
| Experiment | One conflict resolved four ways and scored for the aircraft, the airline, the sector and the system | Sections 3 and 4.3 |
| Traceability chain | One thread from the airline's cost objective through the requirements and the airline-to-ATC interface to the experiment's outcome table | Section 4.3; Appendix A.3 |
| Gap analysis | The requirements that today's NAS does not meet, and what the experiment measures for each | Section 4 |

Table 2: Project milestones and verification methods of the original plan, with the status of each.

| **Project Milestone** | **Deliverable** | **Lead/Team Member** | **Expected Completion Date** | **Target Metric/Verification Method** | **Status** |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Literature Review | Annotated bibliography | Owen | 9/7/2026 | 10–20 papers categorized | Draft |
| PESTLE Analysis & Systems-of-Interest Definition | Context diagram, text-based documentation | Owen | 9/10/2026 | Review | Complete |
| Systems-of-Interest Definition | Text-based documentation | Owen | 9/15/2026 | Clear boundaries and exclusions | Complete |
| Operational Scenarios | ConOps document | Owen | 9/22/2026 | 1–3 representative scenarios | Draft |
| Draft Architecture | BDDs and package structure | Owen | 10/1/2026 | All domains represented | Complete |
| Interface Definition | Interface Control Document | Owen | 10/12/2026 | All interfaces identified | Draft |
| Internal Block Diagrams | IBDs | Owen | 10/17/2026 | Critical interfaces connected | Draft |
| Requirements Definition | Requirements model | Owen | 10/20/2026 | Trace to stakeholders | Draft |
| Measures of Effectiveness | MOE/MOP hierarchy | Owen | 10/25/2026 | Quantifiable metrics defined | Complete |
| Requirement Traceability | Requirements matrix | Owen | 10/29/2026 | Complete allocation | Draft |
| Activity Diagrams | Operational activities | Owen | 11/3/2026 | Scenario walkthrough | Draft |
| Sequence Diagrams | Information exchanges | Owen | 11/8/2026 | Message completeness | Not started |
| State Machines | State behavior of key entities | Owen | 11/13/2026 | Executable state logic | Will not implement |
| Authority & Responsibility Models | RACII (Responsible, Accountable, Consulted, Informed) | Owen | 11/17/2026 | All decisions assigned | Will not implement |
| Optimization Prototype | Working code | Owen | 11/21/2026 | Unit test cases | Draft |
| Integration into MBSE Architecture | Traceability links | Owen | 11/24/2026 | End-to-end scenario | |
| Final Baseline & Final Paper | Versioned model & thesis/paper | Owen | 12/16/2026 | Draft | Not started |
| Paper Submittal | Thesis/paper | Owen | 12/20/2026 | Official submittal | Not started |

# 2 Assumptions and Methodology

The problem is that the inertia of past, piecemeal designs and the high cost of upgrading the NAS make the system hard to change. The project proposes a new airline-to-ATC interface and a new way of deciding which aircraft to move in a conflict, which together could lower the cost of air traffic management.

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md Track C (owner's note, 2026-10-13 print, page 13) — "Expand upon."** The paragraph above is bracketed with this note. Not drafted by Claude: no source in `evidence/source-register.md` has been read for the inertia of past designs or the cost of upgrading the NAS, so the expansion is yours, or name the source and it can be read first.

Toward those ends, the project uses a model-based systems engineering (MBSE) approach to design the architecture and the decision-making process, and a simulation-based experiment to test the proposed interface and decision-making process. First, a literature review was conducted to:

1. identify the current state of air traffic management,
2. identify the relevant stakeholders and their objectives,
3. identify the requirements necessary to meet those objectives, and
4. identify the gaps in the current system that the proposed interface and decision-making process can address.

## 2.1 Systems Engineering Approach

Standard systems engineering methods of analysis and decomposition were applied to the collected evidence, which produced a context diagram, internal block diagrams, and activity and sequence views. These identified the relevant systems and the interactions among them that are necessary to meet the stakeholders' objectives. From them the stakeholder requirements were written and then decomposed into system-level requirements (SLRs) for the NAS. The SLRs were allocated to the relevant constituent systems, and high-level requirements (HLRs) decomposed them one level further.

This enabled the project to (1) build a model of the architecture and the decision-making process, and (2) compare current air traffic management practice, which relies on general rules of thumb and knowledge of what has worked before [73, 55], with a model-based decision-support approach that replaces the low-fidelity decision rule with one or more higher-fidelity models of aircraft performance, at varying levels of accuracy and information.

The emphasis is on structure, behavior, interfaces, and traceability, not on optimization mathematics. The project's commercial value to the author lies in a better understanding of the systems, their interactions, and the divisions of responsibility that inhibit information flow and lead to suboptimal outcomes. To explore that in a meaningful way, decision support and optimization are treated as a capability inside the architecture, which following MBSE principles makes possible.

**AI-DRAFTED, owner to rewrite** — The two paragraphs below are yours, reworded by Claude for your note "Reword" on the 2026-10-13 print (page 15). The claims are unchanged; your originals are in git history (commit 965f5d5).

The systems and their constituent systems could be documented in more detail (examples are in Appendix A.3), and more formal mathematical models could be used. Neither was needed to deliver the project's commercial value to its customer, so neither was done. The project's artifacts were tailored to the customer's needs, as customer-focused MBSE calls for.

The steps of the process were tailored in the same way, to the time the author had available. The literature review began as one pass and then continued as the work required. The gate-to-gate concept of operations was written informally and refined with publicly available general knowledge of the NAS. No alternative system decomposition was formally explored beyond the initial abstraction decisions. The ISO/IEC/IEEE 15288 technical processes were followed in this tailored form, which the standard provides for.

Table 3 summarizes the systems engineering processes and the artifacts that realize them.

Table 3: Systems engineering processes and the artifacts that realize them.

| Process (15288 / INCOSE) | Artifact in this project | Where |
|---|---|---|
| Stakeholder needs and requirements | 13 stakeholder requirements, each traced to an objective row | `requirements_stakeholders.sysml`; Appendix A.3 |
| System requirements | 23 system requirements, allocated to constituent systems; 28 constituent-system requirements one tier down | `requirements_nas_system.sysml`; `requirements_constituent_systems.sysml` |
| Architecture definition | Context diagram, internal block diagrams, typed interfaces on the thread, activity and sequence views | `cameo_models/`; Section 4.2 |
| System analysis | Experiment at three fidelities, outcome table | `simulation/`; Sections 3 and 4.3 |
| Verification | Verification cases for the improved requirements, run by the experiment | `nas_verification.sysml` |
| Validation | Stakeholder-level reading of the outcome table (who pays) with MoEs or MoPs | Section 4 |

## 2.2 Working Assumptions

The working assumptions fall into two groups: assumptions about the problem and its context, and assumptions about the methodology.

The problem statement assumes that:

- the abstractions used in the model are sufficient to capture the relevant behavior of the system;
- the stakeholders' objectives are comprehensively captured and accurately represented in the model;
- the scenario is sufficient to explore the potential benefit of interconnected MBSE.

Every abstraction was made with the express goal of capturing the relevant behavior of the system, as defined by the stakeholders' objectives. The System of Interest, the NAS as a system of systems, was ratified around the trajectory-intent lifecycle, from enterprise objectives through aircraft motion. An entity is modeled when it has distinct decision authority or execution behavior that is dynamically coupled to in-scope decisions and materially affects cost, safety, workload, schedule reliability, or passenger value. Boundary actors supply objectives, demand, feedback, or rules without being decomposed as decision mechanisms. Exogenous influences enter as constraints or scenario parameters. This criterion preserves the authority and responsibility relationships a system-of-systems architecture needs without expanding the project into a model of every NAS participant.

The methodology assumes that:

- models of every required aircraft type are available;
- the security concerns of sharing airline data can be mitigated;
- the proposed interface can be implemented in the NAS over digital communication channels between the airline and ATC, between the aircraft and ATC, or both;
- the airline reports its weight and cost index accurately;
- the conflict can be treated as a snapshot, with the traffic unchanged while the decision is made;
- the specific scenario presented in the experiment is representative of a larger set of scenarios that generalize to the NAS as a whole.
- wake turbulence is not modeled, so the aircraft are assumed to be separated by more than the minimum wake-separation distance.

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md Track C (owner's note, 2026-10-13 print, page 16)** — Beside the interface and communication-channel assumptions, now one item: **"Combine. Later cite EPP, value for [CI/GW], BADA4 for API models?"** "CI/GW" (cost index and gross weight) is Claude's reading of the handwriting. BADA 4 is not in `evidence/source-register.md`.

The scenario stands for a narrow set of conflicts. Conflicts between two aircraft crossing at the same level are a minority of conflicts: 36 of 256 in the operational data of Rantanen and Wickens [73]. The experiment uses one invented en-route sector and four aircraft. The rule that limits climbs when the weight is unknown is a single threshold (FL350) applied to every aircraft type; it is the modeling assumption of an earlier study, which limited climbs in that way because it did not model aircraft weight [19].

The assumption of accurate information has two parts. An airline could misreport what it shares. The aircraft performance model that turns the shared weight into a cost is itself simplified, and its simplifications are listed separately in Section 3.4.

**AI-DRAFTED, owner to rewrite** — One sentence offered for the misreporting point, not asked for on the print. The source was read in full by Claude on 2026-10-11 and not by you; it concerns flow programs before departure, not a conflict in cruise. Keep it, or strike it.

The risk is documented for a related exchange: where an airline states the relative cost of its route options to the FAA's flow-management automation, the airline would reduce its delays by stating a very high cost [57].

## 2.3 Proposed Airline-to-ATC Interface

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md Track C (owner's question, 2026-10-13 print, page 17)** — **"This shouldn't be its own section here. Where would this fit?"** Not moved; the choice is yours. Claude's suggestion: the proposal is a result of the architecture work, so put it in Section 4.2 as the improved architecture, next to the baseline diagrams, and leave one sentence in Section 3.2 that says cases C and D use it. The other candidate is Section 3.2 itself, which keeps it ahead of the experiment that depends on it.

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md Track C (D-019)** — **Name the digital-thread artifact.** Describe `AirlinePerformanceShare`: what it carries (gross weight, cost index, connection priority; thrust, drag and fuel-flow model identifiers present but not exercised), who sends it (airline operations center or FMS), who receives it (ATC decision support, per D-012 owned by the system that decides), and which requirements it satisfies (SLR-INF-02) and the goal it serves (SLR-CLR-13). State that security is an assumption. **Owner's note, 2026-10-11 print: "important to do"** — position it against ADS-C EPP and Coppenbarger's Table 2 (the same items, a different receiver); a first draft of that positioning follows.

The items the interface carries are not new. Coppenbarger [15] listed take-off weight, thrust and drag factors, and the speed profile as candidates for exchange between an airline and air traffic control, and measured what airline-supplied weight does for the prediction of a climb. In Europe, the Extended Projected Profile is sent over ADS-C to downlink the trajectory that the flight management system predicts [82]. What has kept the items out of use is ownership, not feasibility: weight and speed intent "are considered competitive parameters by airlines and are not available for use" [79]. A second obstacle is the availability of first-principles data for each aircraft type: thrust, drag and fuel flow.

The proposal here keeps the items and changes the receiver and the purpose. In the earlier work the data feeds a trajectory predictor, to make the prediction of one aircraft's flight path more accurate. Here it feeds the decision support of the party that chooses which aircraft to move, to change the choice. This provides for asking "what if" within a mathematical framework. The interface is typed in the model, tagged as part of the improved architecture, and tied to the requirement it satisfies, so the report can point at a model element where the earlier work has a finding in prose. Confidentiality is stated as an assumption: the data is disclosed only to the deciding party, and no security mechanism is modeled.

# 3 Experiment

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S11 — State the central claim** the experiment explores. Still undecided (see `experiment-definition.md` §1 and the hand review notes 1.2, 2.1, 4.1). Answer the objection that the simulation compares two ways of operating and so does not by itself test MBSE.

## 3.1 Scenario

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S11 — Scenario.** Four aircraft in one invented en-route sector, shown as one snapshot: a crossing pair at the same level and two aircraft in trail 2,000 ft below. State which aircraft belong to the same airline, which is late with connections, and the weight of each. Give the level of the crossing pair and say why it is above FL350. Justify the static snapshot by the controller studies that used one ([55], [34]).

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S11 (owner's note, 2026-10-11 print, page 11) — "Justify one scenario (time) and expand as possible."** Say that one scenario is studied because of the time available in one term, name what a second scenario would add, and list the variations that are run on the one scenario (similar weights, the climb closed, a crossing pair at or below FL350).

## 3.2 Cases and Resolution Options

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S11 — The one thing that differs between cases.** Define cases A to D by what the decider knows. State what "automated decision" means for who devises and who issues the clearance (undecided). State that the levers are the same in every case.

Table 4: The four cases. Wording to be the author's.

| Case | Decider | Information | Climb rule applies? |
|---|---|---|---|
| A | Controller, by rule | Type, level, speed, route | Yes |
| B | Automation | Nominal weight per type | Yes |
| C | Automation | Shared weight and cost index | No |
| D | Automation | Shared weight, cost index and delay margin | No |

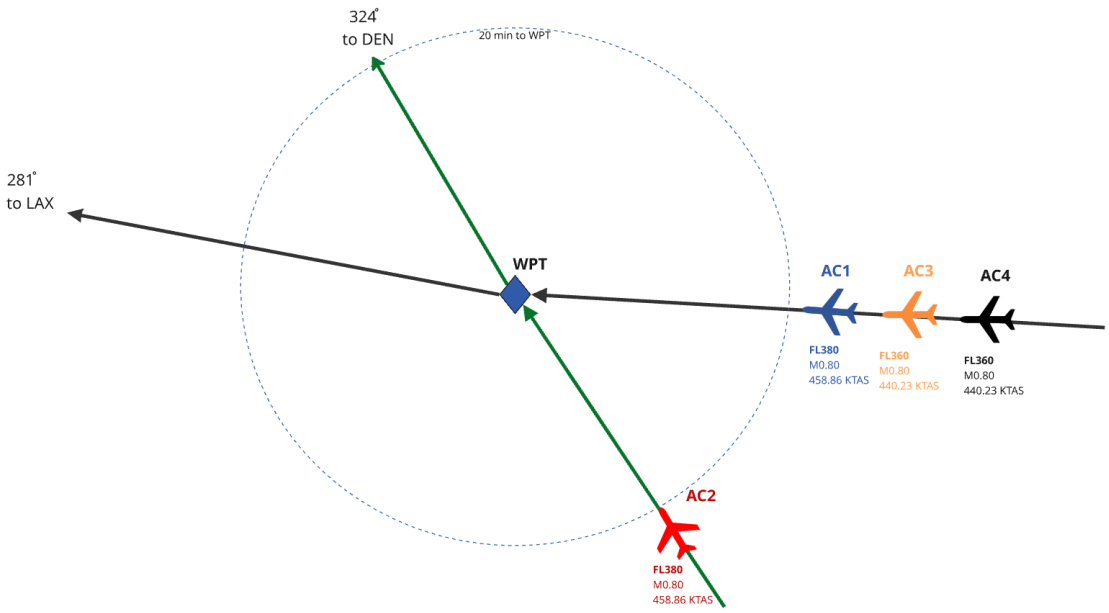



Figure 5: The scenario in plan view. AC1 and AC2 cross at the waypoint at FL380; AC3 and AC4 follow AC1's track at FL360.

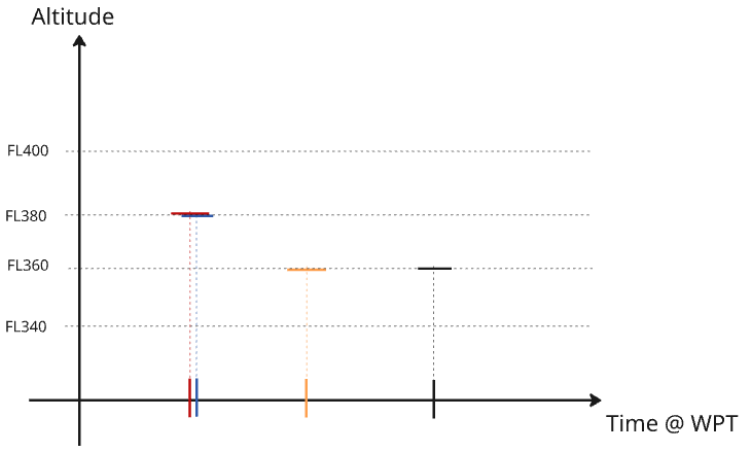



Figure 6: Level of each aircraft against its time at the waypoint. AC1 and AC2 arrive together at FL380.

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S11 — Altitude options and the climb rule (assumption adopted from a prior study).** State the three altitude options (2,000 ft above, 2,000 ft below, 4,000 ft below) and the rule that a climb is offered only at or below FL350, citing [19] (p. 8). Say plainly that this is that study's modeling assumption, made because it did not model aircraft weight; it is not an FAA rule and not observed controller behaviour. Then explain why the rule binds cases A and B and not cases C and D: this is the mechanism by which missing information removes an option.

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S11 — Baseline rule for case A.** One descent clearance, citing [73]. State which aircraft descends and the tie-breaker (undecided), and whether the aircraft is cleared back up.

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S11 — Resolution options.** Introduce Table 5. For each option give the instructions it costs now, the follow-up it creates, and what the decider must know to use it. Cite [34] for the instruction accounting.

Table 5: Resolution options. A dash means no instruction. Full version with instruction counts in Appendix A.5.

| Option | AC1 | AC2 | AC3 | AC4 |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| O1 | Descend 2,000 ft | – | – | – |
| O2 | – | Descend 2,000 ft | – | – |
| O3 | Climb 2,000 ft | – | – | – |
| O4 | – | Climb 2,000 ft | – | – |
| O5 | Turn behind AC2 | – | – | – |
| O6 | – | Turn behind AC1 | – | – |
| O7 | Reduce speed | – | – | – |
| O8 | Descend 4,000 ft | – | – | – |
| O9 | Descend 2,000 ft | – | Slow or turn | – |

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S11 — Sources for the option set and the counts** (owner's note, second hand review, 2.4: "Add these to report!"). Levers: `experiment-definition.md` §4, and [19] (p. 8) for lateral and altitude changes; that study does not use speed. Altitude steps and climb rule: [19] (p. 8), with the authors' reason. Instruction counts: [34] (pp. 72–74). Climbs used less than descents: [73] (6 of 36). Speed limited to ±0.04 Mach and built to fail: the author's own figure, to be stated as experience.

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S11 — The baseline is not hobbled** (owner's note, second hand review, 3.2). In the later variation at or below FL350 the baseline may climb and does not, because its rule is one descent. Say that this matches the observed preference for descents ([73]). **Owner's note, 2026-10-11 print: "Also note higher alt ∼ optimal"** — say that the higher level is near the optimum for these aircraft (Figure 13), so a baseline that never climbs is giving something up.

## 3.3 Scoring

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S11 — What the system column is** (owner's notes, second hand review, 5.5 and 6.1). State that it is a measure of the airspace as a whole system of systems, define it by its cost statement (total fuel, total CO2, total airline cost, workload items, largest cost to any one aircraft), and refer back to that statement wherever the column is discussed.

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S11 — How each option is scored, one statement per viewpoint.** Aircraft: extra fuel plus cost index times extra time ([69], Eq. 1–3). Airline: the sum over its aircraft plus a step cost when a flight misses a connection, plus CO2 converted to dollars. Sector: clearances issued, effort to devise them, and residual risk, reported as three separate items. System: totals stated side by side, with no weighted sum (D-013). Say why no weighted sum: nobody in the model owns the weights.

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S11 — Emissions.** State the conversion from fuel to CO2 and its source ([48]). State how CO2 becomes dollars at the airline level and why that route was chosen (credit price, passenger value, or both; undecided), and why the system level keeps CO2 in kg.

For aircraft $i$ the cost of an option is its extra fuel plus its cost index times its extra time, in kilograms of fuel, the form used in [69]:

$$c_i = \Delta m_{f,i} + CI_i \, \Delta t_i, \tag{1}$$

where the extra fuel $\Delta m_{f,i}$ and the extra time $\Delta t_i$ are the option minus the baseline of flying on undisturbed, and $CI_i$ is the cost index of aircraft $i$ in kilograms of fuel per minute.

Case A applies its rule, one descent. Each automated case chooses, among the options it is allowed to offer, the option whose estimated total of Eq. 1 over all aircraft is lowest. Case B uses the type's nominal mass for every aircraft and values time at 1 kg/min. Cases C and D use each aircraft's actual mass and cost index. Case D also rejects an option that delays a flight with connections past its threshold. Whatever a case chooses is then scored at the actual masses, and that score is what the tables report.

Schedule reliability enters as a step: a flight with connections that is delayed past its threshold incurs a cost $K$ on top of Eq. 1. No sourced value of $K$ is held, so the tables report whether the threshold is crossed, not a dollar figure. Carbon dioxide is 3.16 kg per kilogram of fuel [48]. Instructions are counted, now and later, and are not converted to anything.

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S11 (candidate figure) — Figure 7 is another paper's figure.** It is Figure 1 of [72], placed here because it shows the step in the cost of delay that $K$ stands for. Decide: keep it as a reproduction with the credit in the caption, redraw it for this scenario, or remove it.

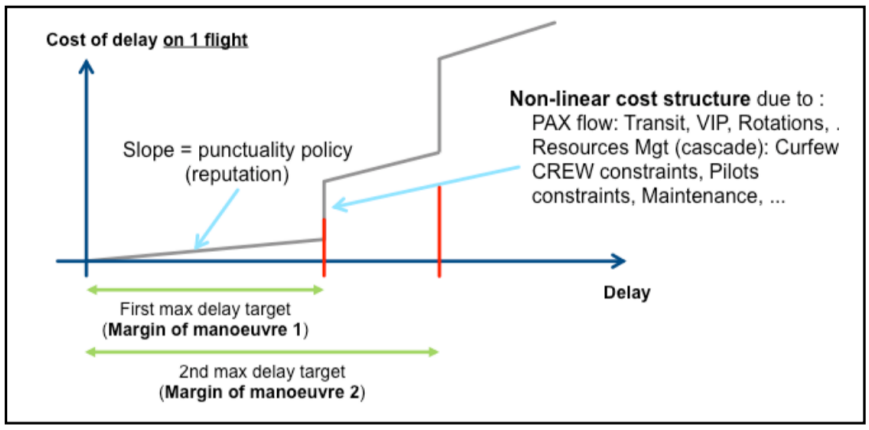



Figure 1: Typical cost-delay model profile per flight

Figure 7: Cost of delay for one flight, with steps where a margin is exceeded. Reproduced from [72], Figure 1.

## 3.4 Aircraft Model and Its Simplifications

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S11, S12 — Truth model (decided, D-017).** OpenAP (open aircraft performance model, TU Delft) scores every option: fuel flow, thrust and drag for the B737-9 at the aircraft's actual mass. State the three selectable fidelities (conceptual: feasibility and instruction counts only; nominal mass; actual mass) and that the decider's case (A to D) and the truth model's fidelity are independent settings. The earlier kinematic model (`vehicle_dynamics.py`) is not used by the experiment.

Each aircraft is a point mass in steady flight at a constant Mach number. Drag, maximum thrust and fuel flow are taken from OpenAP [88], which uses a two-term drag polar and, above 30,000 ft, the two-shaft turbofan thrust model of Bartel and Young [3]. Table 6 lists the values OpenAP holds for the type.

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S11, S12 (owner's note, 2026-10-11 print, page 13) — "Cite another paper for this content. Don't re-create."** The OpenAP paper is now held (`evidence/sources/sun2020openap_aerospace-07-00104.pdf`) and was read in full by Claude on 2026-10-11. The author has not read it. Bartel and Young is not held, and is cited here only through the OpenAP paper, which reproduces its equations. Read Sections 5 and 7 of the OpenAP paper (pp. 6 to 17) before submission. What the paper says about its own accuracy is in `evidence/literature-notes/summaries/4 - sun2020openap.md` and belongs in the discussion of the truth model's uncertainty (Section 4.3).

Table 6: Values OpenAP 2.6.2 uses for the B737-9 (type code B39M), read from the installed package on 2026-10-11.

| Quantity | Value | Note |
|---|---|---|
| Wing area $S$ | 124.6 m$^2$ | type data |
| Zero-lift drag coefficient $C_{D0}$ | 0.020 | 737 MAX 8 polar, borrowed |
| Induced drag factor $k$ | 0.042 | 737 MAX 8 polar, borrowed |
| Engines $n$, type | 2, LEAP-1B | type data |
| Static thrust per engine $T_0$ | 111,300 N | engine data |
| Reference thrust $T_{cr}$ | 46,300 N (both engines) | $0.2\,T_0 + 890$ N per engine |
| Reference cruise $M_{cr}$, altitude | 0.79, 11,000 m | type data |
| Take-off fuel flow $s$ | 0.877 kg/s per engine | ICAO databank |
| Fuel curve $c_1$, $c_2$, $c_3$ | 0.9376, 1.9768, 1.3955 | package default curve, not fitted to this type |

A descent is flown at 1,500 ft/min. A climb is flown at maximum thrust, at the rate that thrust allows and no more than 1,500 ft/min. A level is available to an aircraft only if it would still have 150 ft/min of climb left there. Cases A and B do not know the mass and so cannot make that test; they offer a climb only at or below FL350, which the scenario does not explore. Cases C and D make it at the aircraft's actual mass.

Figure 8 is drawn assuming lift equals weight. Its low-speed boundary is 1.3 times the stall speed at an assumed clean maximum lift coefficient, and its high-speed boundary is the more restrictive of the maximum operating Mach number and the maximum operating speed (VMO). The aircraft's present level and Mach number are marked, and each altitude and speed instruction the scenario offers it is marked as inside or outside the region with 150 ft/min of climb left.

The model makes the following simplifications.

1. **Standard atmosphere, no wind, lift equal to weight.** Time differences come only from true airspeed and added track distance.

2. **No compressibility drag.** The drag used here has no Mach-number term. The OpenAP paper does include one, a wave-drag term above a critical Mach number, and says the effect "should not be ignored" there [88]; the installed package leaves the term off unless asked and marks it experimental, and the experiment runs with it off. The FAA classes flight from Mach 0.75 to 1.20 as transonic [22], so the scenario's Mach 0.80 is at the low end of that range. With OpenAP's experimental wave-drag term switched on, drag at Mach 0.80 is 2 to 4 percent higher. That is 1.3 kN for the heavy aircraft at FL380, against 2.7 kN of excess thrust, so its climb left falls from 181 to 93 ft/min, under the 100 ft/min of the service ceiling.

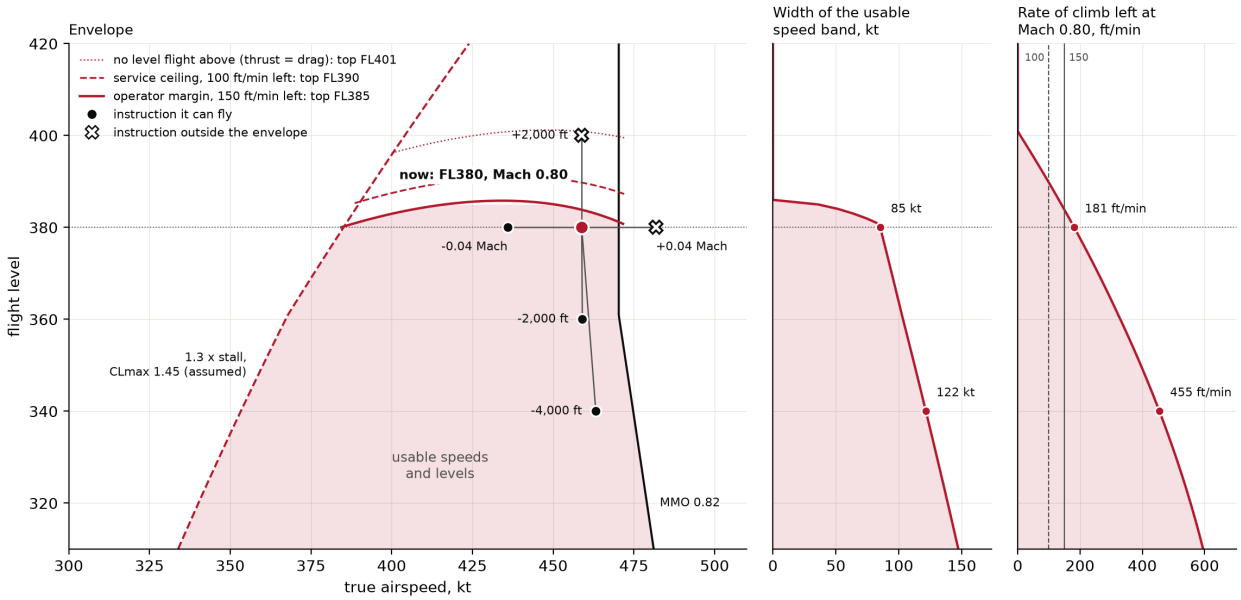



Figure 8: The heavy B737-9 (71.0 t) has little room left to change speed or level at FL380. Left: cruise envelope, with three lines of constant rate of climb left: 0 ft/min (thrust equals drag), 100 ft/min (the service ceiling, [22]) and 150 ft/min (the operator margin the scenario uses). Right: width of the usable speed band and rate of climb left at Mach 0.80, by flight level.

The light aircraft at FL400 falls from 322 to 239 ft/min and still clears 150. The weights in the scenario were set with the term off. Not decided: whether to switch the term on and set the weights again.

3. **The drag polar is the 737 MAX 8's.** OpenAP has none for the 737 MAX 9.

4. **The fuel curve is the package default.** OpenAP has no fuel model fitted to the 737 MAX 9 or MAX 8; it uses its default coefficients scaled by the LEAP-1B take-off fuel flow. The installed version of the package (2.6.2) uses a different curve from the one the OpenAP paper describes, so the paper is the source of the fuel-flow data (the ICAO engine emissions databank) and the package is the source of the curve.

5. **The climb margins.** The service ceiling is the level with 100 ft/min of climb left [22]. The 150 ft/min the experiment requires is commonly observed in practice.

6. **One climb rate per climb.** The rate is taken at the mid-altitude and held; the climb is not integrated. A climb is not checked against the time left before the crossing.

7. **Mass is constant.** Fuel burned during the manoeuvre does not reduce the mass.

8. **The low-speed limit rests on an assumed maximum lift coefficient** ($C_{L\,\max} = 1.45$) and is a stall margin, not a buffet boundary.

9. **A speed change on the crossing pair is not calculated.** It is marked unable to separate the pair by construction.

# 4 Results and Discussion (Preliminary)

**REQUIRED FOR INTERIM REPORT #2 (due 2026-10-25)** — Results and Discussion (preliminary). For Interim Report #2 this section needs: (1) the architecture as it stands (context diagram, aircraft IBD, the three requirements tagged `improved` as the measured gap) — the figures are now in Sections 1.6 and 4.2; (2) the two hand checks from `experiment-definition.md` §9 written up as preliminary results; (3) the first OpenAP numbers — Figure 13 and Table 7 are in place, the discussion is not; (4) one paragraph on what is not yet done.

## 4.1 Operational Concept

The operational concept was first written in full detail as a gate-to-gate thread for one nominal commercial flight, from the pilot's point of view. It runs through eleven phases: the airline's schedule, fleet and crew assignment; the pilot's preparation before duty; reporting and the dispatch release; aircraft preflight and initialization of the flight management system; boarding, loading and fueling; clearance, pushback and taxi; takeoff and initial climb; climb; cruise; arrival planning; and descent through to the gate. Each phase records its initial state, the interfaces in use, and the questions it raised. The full thread is in Appendix A.1.

The model carries an abstraction of that thread. Figure 9 shows six actions in sequence: plan the flight, prepare for departure, depart, fly en route, arrive, and close out the flight. The eleven phases were reduced to six because the study concerns one decision in cruise. The phases before departure and after arrival fix the conditions that decision inherits (the aircraft's weight, its cost index, its schedule position) and are kept at the level needed to show where those conditions come from. Detail is added only where the studied decision is made.

The example conflict sits inside the fly en route action. Two aircraft in cruise are predicted to cross at the same level at the same time. The sector controller must move one of them, and each choice costs fuel, time and instructions that fall on different parties. The nominal thread treats a trajectory change in cruise as one step; the experiment of Section 3 opens that step and asks what the decider knows when making it.

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S5** — Decompose `FlyEnroute` one level in `nas_activity_diagram-nominal_ops.sysml` so the conflict-resolution step appears on Figure 9, then check the three paragraphs above against the diagram. Put the full activity breakdown in Appendix A.1.

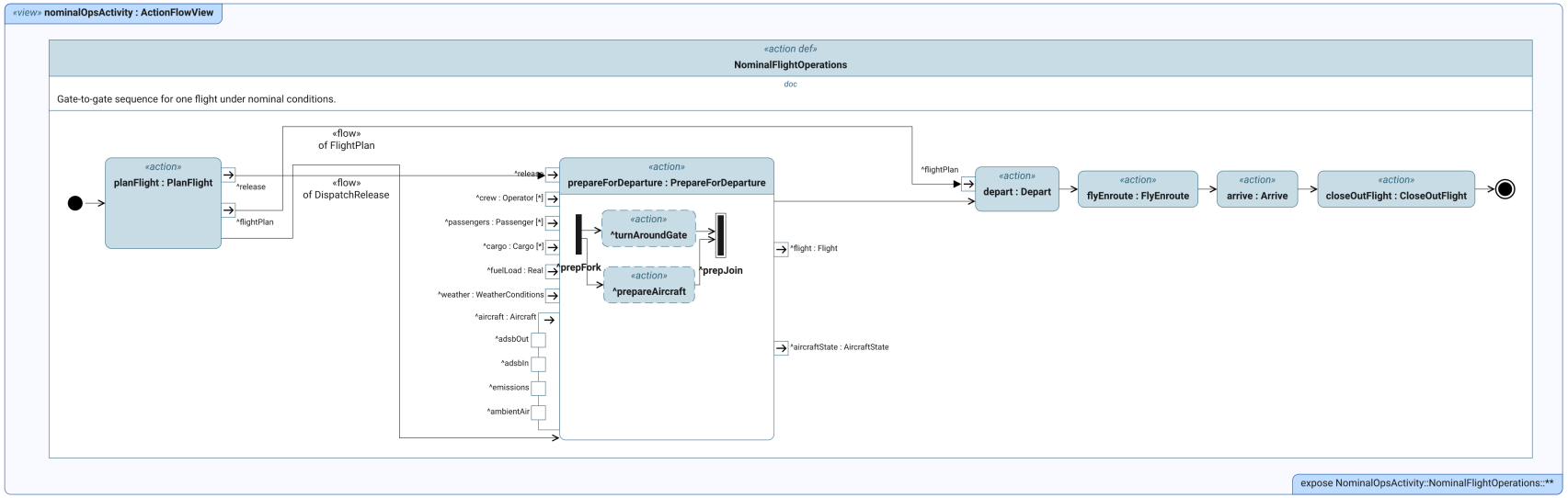



Figure 9: Nominal flight operations activity diagram (draft: no swimlanes, sub-actions are placeholders). View `nominalOpsActivity`; source `nas_activity_diagram-nominal_ops.sysml`; rendered 2026-10-10.

## 4.2 Architecture: Detailed and Abstracted

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S10** — Present the SysML architecture: package structure, the context diagram (Figure 4), the internal block diagrams below, the interface and item-flow model, and the requirements model with traceability. For the aircraft, the detailed diagram comes first and the abstracted one second (your note: "Place detailed and abstracted"); say what the abstraction drops and why. The airspace management diagram is still a placeholder.

**AI-DRAFTED, owner to rewrite** — Two connecting sentences so the figures are referred to from the text. Replace with your own description of what each level of detail shows.

The aircraft is shown at two levels of detail. Figure 10 is the detailed internal block diagram, including propulsion, airframe, landing gear, utilities, and the fuel and power links. Figure 11 is the abstraction used in the rest of the report: the crew, the flight deck controls, the avionics, the flight controls, the fuel system, and the information and command links among them, which are the parts the studied decision passes through. Figure 12 shows the internals of airspace management as modeled so far.

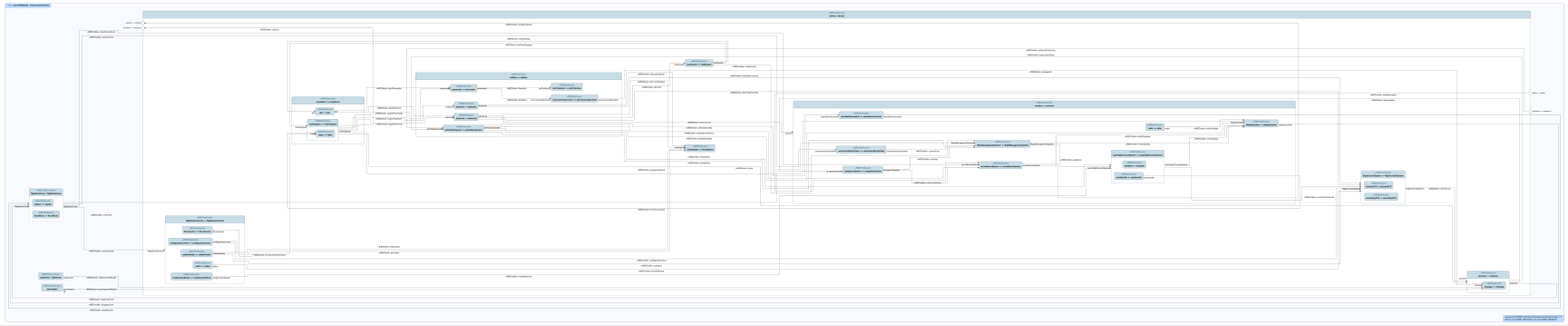


Figure 10: Aircraft internal block diagram, detailed level: adds propulsion, airframe, landing gear, utilities, and the fuel and power links. View `aircraftIbdDetail`; source `nas_ibd_aircraft.sysml`; rendered 2026-10-10.

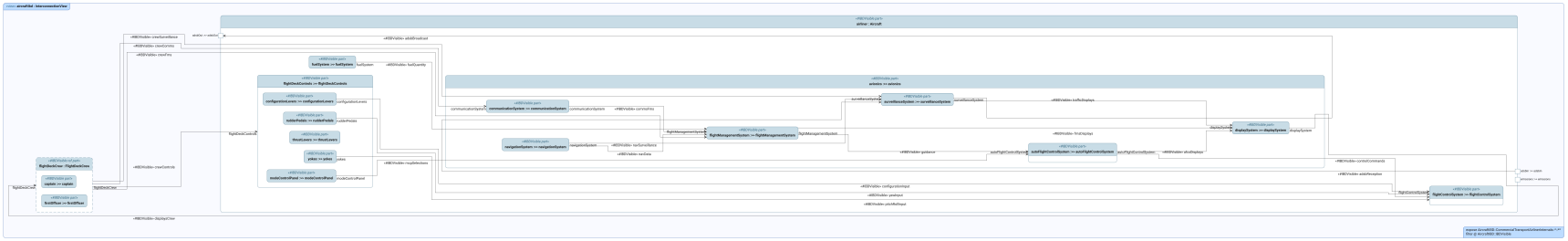


Figure 11: Aircraft internal block diagram, default level of detail. View `aircraftIbd`; source `nas_ibd_aircraft.sysml`; rendered 2026-10-10.

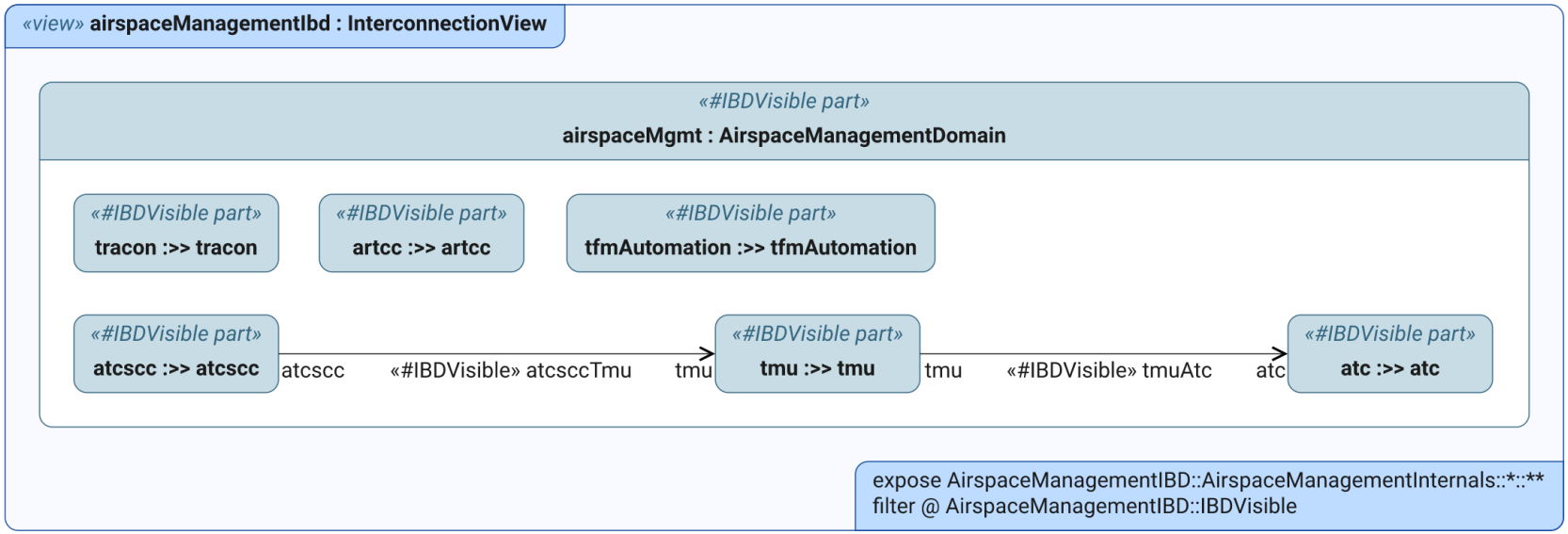



Figure 12: Airspace management internal block diagram. View `airspaceManagementIbd`; source `nas_ibd_airspace_management.sysml`; rendered 2026-10-10.

### 4.3 Experiment Results

Table 7: Outcome of each case at four levels, for the base scenario scored at the actual masses. Each cost is a difference from flying on undisturbed. Preliminary: the scenario's numbers are not all confirmed.

| Case | Option | Largest cost to any one aircraft (kg fuel-equiv.) | Airline totals (USD) | Sector (calls / effort / risk) | System fuel, CO2 (kg) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| A | O8 | 32 (AC1) | X 28, Y 0, Z 0 | 1+1 / 1 / low | 32, 101 |
| B | O9 | 11 (AC1) | X 15, Y 0, Z 0 | 2+2 / 3 / medium | 16, 51 |
| C | O4 | 12 (AC2) | X 0, Y 11, Z 0 | 1+1 / 3 / low | 12, 39 |
| D | O4 | 12 (AC2) | X 0, Y 11, Z 0 | 1+1 / 3 / low | 12, 39 |

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S12 — Which option each case chose, and why.** Walk Table 7 row by row. For case A, name the rule that produced the choice. For B, C and D, name the cost that decided it.

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S12 — Did the climb rule matter?** With the crossing pair above FL350, cases A and B could not offer a climb and cases C and D could. Say whether case C used one, for which aircraft, and what it saved. If C did not climb either, say so: that is a result too.

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S12 — B minus A, and C minus B.** The first is what automation is worth; the second is what the information exchange is worth. Compare the size of each with the prior figure of tens of gallons per flight ([19], p. 12) and say whether the difference is larger than the truth model's uncertainty.

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S9, S12 — Does the best option change with the level?** Read across each row of Table 7. Name any option that is better for one aircraft or one airline and worse for the sector or the system, and who pays (the largest cost to any one aircraft). This is the sub-system versus system discussion.

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S12 — Airline X's two flights.** Discuss the option that touches both of one airline's aircraft: what the airline would choose between its late flight and its early one, and that the controller cannot see that preference. Connect to the dispatcher priorities (schedule integrity and connections rated at or above fuel; source of that table still to confirm).

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S12 — Workload is three things.** Discuss clearances issued, effort to devise, and residual risk separately. Say where a "more workload" option on one of them is "less" on another.

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S12 — When would the controller say no?** (owner's note, second hand review, 5.2). Discuss whether refusals are more likely in morning rushes at hub airports or near holidays, using the sector-loading rule in [19] (p. 10). A hypothesis; needs a source.

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S12 — Is schedule the right priority?** (owner's note, second hand review, 4.11). Contrast a carbon price, which makes fuel weigh more against time, with controllers' usual practice of giving schedule the priority.

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md Track A — Figure slot: sequence diagram** of case C's conflict resolution (controller, ATC decision support, airline operations center, FMS, crew), rendered from the model once drafted (turn 3).

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S12 — The case where nothing changes.** Report the variation with similar weights and the climb closed, where case C picks the same option as case B, to show the comparison is not rigged.

**AI-DRAFTED, owner to rewrite** — Where each column of the outcome table lives in the model (your note: "DO"). Part and port names are from `cameo_models/nas_context_diagram.sysml`; the requirement and its tag are from `knowledge/models/requirements-and-traceability.md`. Check the part chosen for each column.

Each column of Table 7 belongs to a part of the context diagram (Figure 4). The aircraft column belongs to the aircraft and its flight crew. The airline column belongs to the airline

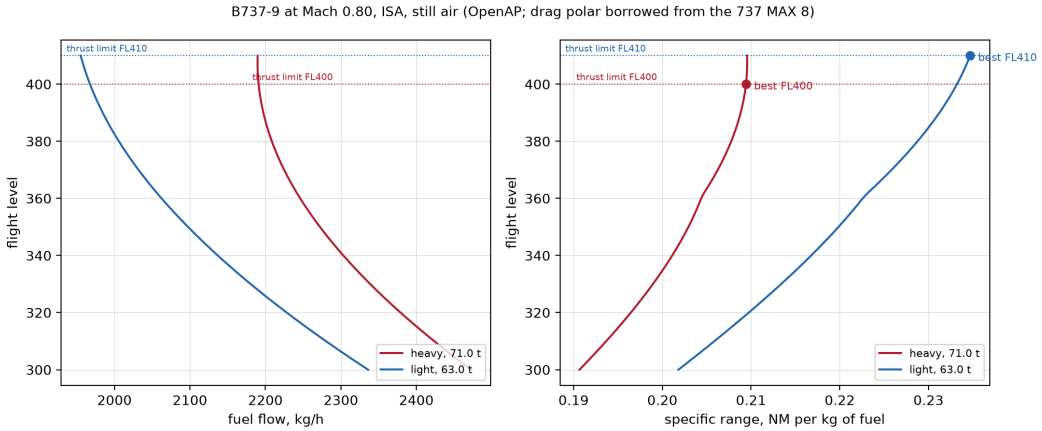



Figure 13: Fuel flow and specific range against altitude at Mach 0.80 for the heavy and light B737-9 (OpenAP).

operations center within flight operations. The sector column belongs to air traffic control within airspace management. The system column belongs to no single part. It is a property of the NAS as a whole, which is the reason no constituent system computes it today and the reason the model is needed to state it.

The exchange that cases C and D add is one interface in the model: the airline operations center's performance share to air traffic control's decision support, carrying gross weight, cost index and the flight's delay margin. It satisfies system requirement SLR-INF-02, which is tagged as part of the improved architecture because today's NAS does not meet it. The interface is not drawn on Figure 4, which shows the baseline.

## 4.4 Emissions and Who Pays

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S9, S12 — Airline level: put CO2 into dollars.** Take the fuel difference between cases from Table 7, convert to kg of CO2, then to dollars. State the route used and its source. Candidates: (1) the price of a carbon credit or allowance, if a scheme applies to the flight; (2) passenger value, meaning revenue gained or lost because some passengers choose the flight listed with lower emissions. Make the point that fuel is already counted once as fuel cost and that pricing its CO2 counts the same kilograms again, on purpose. SOURCES NOT YET HELD.

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S9, S12 — Passenger value.** Discuss how passengers see a flight's emissions when booking, and whether that reaches the airline as demand. The author's own practice of choosing lower-emission listings is the motivation, not the evidence: cite a study. Note the gap between one decision in one sector and the label a passenger saw at booking; the link is the airline's average over many flights.

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S12 — Scale it honestly.** One conflict in one sector is a small number. If a per-year or fleet-wide figure is offered, state the multiplier and its source (for example, how often level crossing conflicts occur), and label it illustrative.

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S9 — Who pays.** For the option the system prefers, name the aircraft or airline that is worse off and by how much. This is the equity discussion.

# 5 Impact/Financial Benefits

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S9, S12 (S16 bullet added this session)** — Quantify the impact of the reference architecture and its experiment. Translate the conflict analysis and the experiment's results into concrete operational terms wherever possible (e.g., delay-minutes, fuel burn, CO2, instructions issued) and into US-dollar terms where a credible conversion exists (e.g., published cost-per-delay-minute figures from the literature review, Section 1.2). Also discuss the ethical context and any unintended consequences of the recommendations (equity-minded engineering: whose costs get externalized, and onto whom – this connects directly to the objectives whose costs are externalized onto another stakeholder, Section 1.7, and to Section 4.4).

**Scope flag:** the 503 template expects a quantified financial-benefit statement (the template's sample statements are dollar-savings claims from industry DMAIC-style projects). This capstone is an architecture/SoS project, not a cost-reduction project with a "before" baseline in dollars, so a literal dollar-savings figure may not be available or meaningful. Recommend framing impact primarily in operational/systems terms (delay, fuel, emissions, predictability, tradeoff-surface shape) with a dollar estimate offered as an illustrative, clearly-caveated secondary figure rather than the headline metric.

# 6 Conclusions and Recommendations

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S15, S16** — Briefly restate the problem, approach, and findings, including potential benefits in relative terms if absolute figures are sensitive or incomplete (e.g., "reduces network-level delay propagation by an illustrative X% under the demonstrated scenario" rather than an unsupported absolute claim). Cover: known architecture omissions, limitations of the selected decomposition (S6), limitations of the experiment (Sections 2.2 and 3.4), and opportunities for future expansion (e.g., additional off-nominal scenarios, unexplored S9 conflicts, deeper crew/maintenance-routing integration).

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S14, S15 — Recommendations.** Restate the main findings from Section 4 and provide recommendations for moving forward. Include the alternatives considered (alternative stakeholder-weighting schemes from S11) and the criteria used to select the recommended approach. Suggest additional areas of study (candidate: architecture extensions, additional off-nominal scenarios from S15, unexplored myopic-optimization conflicts from S9's catalog).

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# A Appendices

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S5, S7, S10, S11 (general)** — Use appendices for material too extensive for the main body or of interest to only some readers. Label each lettered (Appendix A, B, ...), and ensure every appendix is referenced from somewhere in the main body.

## A.1 Full Nominal-Flight ConOps

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S5** — Full strategic-planning through postflight/continuation activity breakdown (see main-body summary, Section 4.1).

## A.2 Full Stakeholder Register and RACCI Matrix

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S7** — Complete stakeholder register (needs, goals, responsibilities, authorities, resources, constraints, information needs, measures of value) and the full RACCI matrix around operational decisions.

**AI-DRAFTED, owner to rewrite** — Excerpt of the stakeholder assessment. Ten of the workbook's 48 rows and four of its thirteen columns, chosen by Claude to show each recommended treatment. Choose your own rows, or replace the excerpt with the whole sheet.

Table 8: Excerpt of the stakeholder assessment (`capstone_stakeholder_assessment.xlsx`): ten of 48 candidates. Score is importance (high 3, medium 2, low 1) plus trajectory-decision impact (yes 2, indirect 1, no 0).

| Stakeholder (PESTLE domain) | Trajectory-decision impact | Standalone importance | Score | Recommended treatment |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Airlines (economic) | Yes | High | 5 | Standalone |
| Airports (economic) | Yes | High | 5 | Standalone |
| Air traffic controllers (technical) | Yes | High | 5 | Standalone |
| Dispatchers (technical) | Yes | High | 5 | Standalone |
| Flight crews (social) | Indirect | High | 4 | Consider / consolidate |
| Local communities (environmental) | Indirect | High | 4 | Consider / consolidate |
| Federal Aviation Administration (political) | No | High | 3 | Consider / consolidate |
| Passengers (economic) | No | High | 3 | Consider / consolidate |
| Aircraft manufacturers (economic) | Indirect | Low | 2 | Boundary input / omit |
| Congress and legislatures (political) | No | Low | 1 | Boundary input / omit |

## A.3 Full SysML Diagram Set

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S10** — Diagrams not embedded in the body: full BDD/IBD set, requirements model, and complete traceability matrices (needs → objectives → requirements → systems → activities → information exchanges → aircraft behavior). Not yet modeled as views: BDDs and the requirements model.

Every figure of the model in this report is a view defined in `nas_package_my_views.sysml` and rendered from the SysML v2 text with Syside. Its caption names the view, the `.sysml` file that

holds the content, and the date of the render. As of this draft all five views appear in the body: Figure 4 (Section 1.6), Figure 9 (Section 4.1), and Figures 10, 11 and 12 (Section 4.2). Views added to the model later appear below.

## A.4 Full Myopic-Optimization Conflict Catalog

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S9** — All candidate conflicts not carried into the main-body discussion or the S11–S14 demonstration scenario, each with: decision maker, decision variable, local objective/constraints, affected stakeholders, externalized costs, SoS consequence, and information needed to recognize the consequence.

## A.5 Optimization Experiment Detail

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S11, S12** — Full experiment matrix, constituent-model validation notes, and any sensitivity-analysis detail not included in Section 4.

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S11** — Full options table: for each of the nine options, the maneuver per aircraft, instructions now, follow-up later, and what the decider must know to use it. Draft in `knowledge/models/experiment-options-and-scoring.md` §2.

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S11, S12** — Every option scored at four levels (the table from which each case picks one row), the per-viewpoint cost statements with their symbols defined, and the table of abstractions with reason and risk.

## A.6 Generative AI Use Disclosure

**REQUIRED FOR INTERIM REPORT #2 (due 2026-10-25)** — Generative AI disclosure: owner to draft. Required by the course policy whenever GenAI is used; Interim Report #2 is the first submission after the policy was read (2026-09-21).

## A.7 Source Register

**Plan ref: to-do-list.md S1–S4** — Reference or reproduce the evidence/source register (`evidence/source-register.md`): source, publication type, NAS lifecycle phase, systems/stakeholders addressed, architectural and optimization evidence extracted, and confidence/limitations.